

Jayalalithaa

AIADMK

S

- Acceptable to all the fronts, she is flexible enough to ensure that she gets her share of power.
- Will be more acceptable as prime minister for the Third Front than Mayawati due to her English language skills and finesse.
- Made early gains by wooing the DMK allies like the PMK.

W

- Another matinee idol Vijayakanth is eating into her electoral box office.
- Will have to support the UPA to ensure that the Congress breaks ties with the DMK in Tamil Nadu.
- Back-flipping from her earlier stance, she is projecting herself as a champion of Lankan Tamils.



S: Strengths; W: Weaknesses

ence from alliances led by the Big Two—the Congress and BJP. And they are not bound by the exigencies of pre-election alliances. As each of them has its own manifesto, their action will be motivated not by conviction but convenience. With the so-called national parties failing to fire the national imagination, competitive provincialism has turned the 15th Lok Sabha elections into an anthology of state elections.

Statistics favour smaller parties who are busy forming new alliances or watering down older ones. Not even generous forecasters are giving the ruling UPA and the opposition NDA over 220 seats. National politics is getting increasingly multipolar as the Congress and BJP are fighting head on only in six states—Rajasthan, Delhi, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Himachal Pradesh. It is going to be an election dominated by

provincial pachyderms, and they are straying beyond their pastures: Mayawati has fielded over 500 candidates across the country; the CPI is hoping to win a seat in Manipur; the CPI(M) boasts of a “sure seat” in Rajasthan; and the NCP is eyeing a seat in Orissa.

The Third Front has its share of sub-plots and recent events have only helped the commissar. Karat collected his assets while the prime minister spent his time on the nuclear deal and resolved not to get involved in the humdrum of coalition politics. The Telangana Rashtra Samiti left the UPA in September 2006 over the demand for a Telangana state. The MDMK left the alliance on March 16 over its differences with DMK. The Left parties themselves removed the crutches on July 8 last year

over the nuclear deal. In January, the PDP left after the Congress made a pact with the National Conference. Then it was the turn of the PMK which left after its differences with the DMK.

Karat knows well that local designs in his latest summer collection had played a crucial role when the UPA rode to victory in 2004. The RJD-led alliance of the Congress, LJP and the Left parties had won 30 of the 40 seats in Bihar. Now the Congress, Left and the Lalu-Paswan combine are separately taking on the JD(U). In Andhra, the alliance of the Congress, Left and TRS had pocketed 37 of the 42 seats. The Congress is fighting alone now and the Left has aligned with the TRS and TDP. The DMK-led coalition that included the Congress, Left, MDMK and PMK had captured all 40 seats in Tamil Nadu. Now the Congress is left alone with the DMK. Patnaik, who broke the NDA's